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An Elementary Study of Islamic History

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Introduction

We read history for instruction and delight, and in doing so, we build up our own patterns for an understanding of the past. Historiography is important for the student of history for many reasons, while adding to his knowledge a student can develop his style and define his attitude towards the meaning and purpose of history. A general comparison of the works of the great historians, together with a detailed study of any one of them can be a very useful exercise for a young historian.

According to D.M Study history, in order to be a systematic record and interpretation of the past, depend upon some conditions: (1) the development of the art of writing and the accumulation of written records, (2) The development of a sense of history i.e. an awareness of change and development through time, (3) the development of a critical attitude towards sources and unchecked authorities i.e. the evolution of historical method.

Before the advent of Arab historians or other historians who wrote in Arabic in the Muslim world some Greek historians, viz, Herodotus and Thuydides attained fame in writing history. The former (484-425 B.C) inspite of his credulity and some inaccuracies, was a famous historian because of his wide and varied interests. He undertook tours to many countries like Egypt, Syria, Babyionia, Persia, Greece and Southern Italy to collect data for his history. The Arab historian Masudi resembled him in these respects, and that is why he is called Arab Herodotus. Thucydides (330-399 B.C.) is reputed as a great historian, rationalist in outlook. His method was objective and critical. He strove to be impartial and tried his utmost to ascertain his facts.

Historical Consciousness in islam

Role of the Qur'an and the Hadith

'Islam is a religion with a strong sense of history, rightly observes Bernard Lewis. The two great sources of human knowledge and experience, as described in the Holy Quran, are nature and history, the third source being intuition. Regarding history Bernard Lewis says in 'Historians of the Middle East' that God Himself told stories about the peoples of the past, and indeed the Quran is full of warnings from the lessons of history. The Quran says: 'We tell you stories of the Apostles, which will strengthen yours hearts, and thus bring you the Truth, an exhortation and a reminder for the believers (Quran, XI 120). The Quran describes the stories of the people called 'Ad and Thamud, the Israelites, the people of Noah, the people of Sodom and Gomarrah and many others to enlighten us about their activities which brought them to grief so that we may be cautious about the pitfalls in our path. The Quran draws our attention to the nations of the past who suffered for their misdeeds and violation of God's commands. It says: 'Say (Oh, Muhammad) travel on the earth to find out surely the consequences of those who denied the truth'. the History, according to the Quran; is not the mere narration of good old days. It is a warning against the pitfalls in our path. The historical record is the light house which informs the new sailors of the life about the perilous rocks that may be hidden beneath the surface of the bottomless ocean of human existence." these are the indications which point to the fact that the Holy Quran

provides us with incentive to the study of history. The spirit of the Quran itself is thus conducive to historical research and the development of history of universal history was received by the Muslims in the shape of religious teaching and they proved themselves worthy students of the subject.

Role of Pre-Islamic poems and genealogical tables in the growth of historical consciousness.

The Pre-Islamic description of the 'Battle-days of the Arabs' in Arabic poems and the genealogical tables at best indicate a line of interest and a technique of narration but provide us no idea of history (Lewis). Franz Rosenthal says; 'History loomed very large in Muhammad's thinking'

Prof. Gibb says that it is the Quran which made the Muslims 'History-Conscious.' Nevertheless, "The Arabs had a kind of historical tradition, says Lewis, even before the beginning of Islam, the so called Ayyam al-Arab or battle days of the Arabs, which described in real detail campaigns between two or more tribes and the heroic deeds of their leaders". though this kind of historiography was to a very high degree mythological, yet, in the opinion of Lewis, their proximity to life, their interest in the feeling of the masses and their sense of real and possible detail made them suitable as the nucleus of real historiography reports". The description of the heroic deeds of the tribes and clans in Arabic poems of Pre-Islamic times provided the Muslims with a stimulus to record and preserve the heroic exploits and the noble deeds of their prophet and his companions and of the early heroes of Islam.

In the words of Franz Rosenthal 'the cultural and economic level of the nomad population was, as it has always been too low to support any literary effort.' "The Arabs," writes L.H. Quirieshi, "do not seem to have a word for history. Some of the earlier writers used the term khabar for history. But in khablar forms of history the continuity of a historical process is difficult to convey. Any deep interpretation of facts also is ruled out, because the tendency is to look upon life as a series of separate incidents without much anxiety to discover their interaction." Khabar was narration pure and simple. It was told like a vivid short story, Sometimes containing a few verses to drive a point home or to give a dramatic quality; it was very much like a dramatic dialogue.

Evolution of Muslim Historiography

Muslim historiography began after the rise of Islam. But, as already said, the study of genealogy of the pre-Islamic Arabs and the description of their 'Battle-Days' had their share in imparting a knowledge about the technique of narration through not very definite idea about history. The notion of pride among Pre-Islamic tribes exhibited in their description through the vehicle of poetry was operative even among the Umayyads. Under them the tribal feeling persisted in all its strength among Arabians, one of them, Abid bin Shariyya, was summoned by Muawiyah, the founder of the Umayyad Caliphate, to relate the history of the Kings of Yaman, Abid bin Shariyya composed a book of kings and of past history which was very much in demand in the first century of Islam.

The Maghazi

An important group of materials to which very scanty attention has been paid by western scholars is called Maghazi material. This is to be taken to mean such information as the list of expeditions, the aim of each and the actual results, the leader and the number, and the names of the participants, etc. This information is usually given without any Isnad both by Ibn Ishaq and al-Waqidi.

Little of the Maghazi material can be derived from the Quran, where some of the expeditions only have been mentioned. It must be the result of the work of the students of the Maghazi, questioning large numbers of persons and sifting and arranging the information is obtained. This process continued after Ibn Ishaq. He knows of several expeditions which he seems to be unable to date or place chronologically and this has been improved by al-Waqidi, who had access to more information than Ibn Ishaq. Ibn Hisham too has improved upon Ibn Ishaq in some respects. Ibn Hisham has often added to Ibn Ishaq's account of the name of the man left in charge of Madina when the prophet used to be absent.

Ibn Ishaq

Muhammad Ibn Ishaq is the most famous writer on Maghazi as well as on Sira, and he is regarded as the highest authority, only to be matched by Waqidi, the famous Maghazi writer. But in veracity and trustworthiness Ibn Ishaq even excels Waqidi. He had seen Anas bin Malik one of the companions of the Prophet and had been a great favourite of his teacher Imam Zuhri. Imam Malik has questioned the veracity of Ibn Ishaq since he reported facts which he heard from the Jews. He depended on Ahl-i-Kitab for his sources for part of his book Sirat-i-Rasulullah, the part of which deals with Pre-Islamic Arabia. There are also some other charges against him, according to Prof. Duri. Ibn Ishaq inserted fabricated poems in his Sira. Thirdly he committed mistakes in genealogy. Fourthly, he has given some false references in his work. Fifthly, he has been charged with Shiite tendencies and leanings, and Prof. Duri says that it is not without truth. He was a Qadarite in his belief and conviction. But against the charge that he is anti-Umayyad, Prof. Duri has nothing to say (Prof. Duri: Criticism Ilm-i-Tarikh Indal-Arab). The first book, against Ibn Ishaq however, on the biography of the Prophet was written by Ibn Ishaq for al-Mansur, the Abbasid Caliph.

Sirat-i-Rasulullah

The Sirat-i-Rasulullah of Ibn Ishaq (d. 767 A.D) is not available in its original form. Ibn Hisham brought out a very elaborate and enlarged edition, known as Sirat-i-Ibn Hisham which remains as a relic of its original work. The first book on the campaigns was however, written by Musa bin Uq'ba who died in 758 A.D. About the controversy as to who was the first Muslim, Abu Bakr, Zaid b. Harith or Ali, Ibn Ishaq mentions that it was Ali.

Ibn Hisham

Abdul Malek bin Hisham was born in Basra and died at Fustat in Egypt (213 or 218 A.H) According to Khuda Bakhsh, in the handling of his materials Ibn Hisham shows a distinct advance upon Ibn Ishaq. He reveals greater critical insight, shows an inclination to test the sources from which the information comes and expresses his opinion on their authenticity or otherwise. (Khuda Bakhsh). According to Prof. Duri, Ibn Hisham corrected the false riwayat (reports) in the first part of Ibn Ishaq's book and dropped the fabricated poems. He also brought, according to the above authority his book closer in style with the Muhaddithin (Traditionists)., Ibn Hisham was a Philologist of same repute synate though highly of him.

Ibn Sad

the great work on biography was written by Ibn Sad who was secretary of al-Waqidi, the renowned historian of the Muslim conquests. Ibn Sad's Tabaqat-i-Kabir, Tabaqat-i-Saghir and Tarikh-i-Islam are regarded as more reliable and authentic than the works of his master al-Waqidi, who was patronised by Yahya Barmaki, the Wazir of the Caliph Harun-ar-Rashid. Ibn Sad, the writer of another work Tahdhib at-Tahdhib is also praised for his comprehensive and elaborate work on the lives of the prophet and his companions. Ibn Sad, a Hashimite born in the town of Basra, subsequently settled in Baghdad. the famous historian Baladhuri was his disciple. He passed away in 844 A.A. His Tabaqat in eight volumes deals with the life of the Prophet and the lives of his companions. Ibn Hajar, Ibn Khalikan, Imam Malik and others have praised his authenticity. As already said Ibn Sad's biographies are a mine of useful information.

Al-Waqidi

Al-Waqidi, the master of Ibn Sad wrote two works, Kitab al-Sirah and Kitab al-Tarikh, al-Maghazi. According to Imam Shafei, Waqidi is thoroughly unreliable; since he depended upon Jewish sources of information while writing his work. According to Khuda Bakhsh, stupendous was his literary and historical output. 'In the history of the companions of the Prophet, Khuda Bakhsh says, "he shows a notable advance upon his criticism of his works forerunners in the handling of his materials. His works give us the impression of a connected, coherent historical work, replying with sunni humour, resplendent with a lively style."

According to Prof. Duri, Waqidi is more particular in respect of Isnad than Ibn Ishaq. He was more critical and scientific in his investigation of facts and dates (Ilm-i-Tarikh, Indal-Arab PP. 30-31)" Waqidi also supplied. Prof. Duri says, "topographical and geographical details with regard to the battlefields of the

link between Ibn Sad's *tabaqat-i-Kabir* and Tabari's history. The early historians in fact prepared the way for the great historians like Tabari and Masudi,

Criticism

the *Ansab al-Ashraf*, the genealogies of the nobles, is written on a biographical pattern. Two volumes only of this work are extant. (Hitti). "In spite of all al-Baladhuri's merits", writes Encyclopedia of Islam. His value as a historical source has been occasionally over estimated. It's not correct to say that he always gives the original texts which later writers embellished and expanded. It may be with much more truth presumed that from the agreement of essential portions of his works with later more detailed works that he abridged the material at his disposal in a number of cases though he often remains faithful to his sources. His style aims at conciseness at the expense, at times, of the artistic effect. We seldom meet with long stories, though they do occur. Baladhuri wrote a history of the Muslim conquests which, in the words of Khuda Bakhsh, conspicuous by an absence of pedantry not only exhibits excellence of method, but shows throughout, tact and taste of a cultivated mind accustomed to the best society and freedom from the bondage of the traditionists.

According to Philip Hitti, certain passages of *futuh al-Buldan* are mutilated and ambiguous. But it is free from exaggeration and the flames of imagination. And throughout the work the sincere attempt of the author to get to the fact as it happened and to record it as it reached him is noticeable."

Baladhuri has been quoted freely not only by historians but also geographers. Yaqut in his *Mujam al-Buladan*, and Maqdisi Hamadani and Masudi have extensively used him as a source.

Ibn Qutaiba

Ibn Qutaiba (276A.H/89 A.D) wrote *Kitab al-Ma'arif* (Book of knowledge), a short and compact work. The book begins with the creation and the author cites Biblical passages referring to it and the creation of man and his fall. Then follows the history of the patriarchs according to biblical and Arab legends. The author then deals with those old Arabs who had renounced Pre-Islamic heathenism. This is followed by a section on the genealogy of the Arab tribes supplemented by the biographies of the Prophet, his kinsmen his followers and companions, and finally the caliphs up to the time of the author. The next section contains an account of the famous men of the Muslim world. The book concludes with a history of the south Arabian dynasties of Pre Islamic times and of the Persian kings. This shows that the old traditional view is, to a great extent, discarded and replaced by a wide intellectual vision. The history of the Prophet forms now only a part of the whole work and non Muslim nations claim attention. From a different angle of vision history is now studied. Even the tendency to look at the events of the past not merely from a religious point of view, gains ground.

The passion for history increased more and more. Moreover, history brought in its train archaeology, geography and ethnography.

Historical vision was widened because of Muslim contact with other races following the conquest of many non Muslim countries.

The Age of Tabari and Masudi

Tabari-His merits

After Baladhuri and other historians mentioned above the next great historians were Tabari and Masudi with whom the golden age of Muslim historiography was ushered in. To Mhammad Jarir Abu Jafar al-Tabari we owe two of the most important works. His exhaustive commentary on the Quran and his chronology of Apostles and Kings, entitled Kitab al Muluk-wa-Rasul, brought down to 298 A.H. Tabari acquired eminence in Tradition, Law, reading of the Quran and history.

According to Margoliouth, Tabari is the first great Muslim historian who dealt with the subject in the comprehensive and annalistic method and formed a chronological sense of events. His book on history is the most informative and reliable work. As Margoliouth says, the sequence of events is very important in the art of history writing and Tabari has mentioned it upto the last. The Universal history mentioned above, was ten times bigger in its original form than in its present shape. Tabari has dealt with the history of pre Islamic period in two volumes and he has dwelt upon the life of the Prophet, the pious Caliphs, the Umayyad and the Abbaisd dynasty up to 302 A.H/915 A.D.

Criticism

Some historians based their work on Tabari's history like Ibn Maskawaih and Ibnul Athir. Ibnul Athir's history Al-Kamil fit-Tarikh which comes up to 1123 A.H. is an abbreviation of the work of Tabari with additional developments. Prof. Gibb observes: "The excellence of Tabari is his authority and comprehensiveness which marked the close of an epoch. No later compiler ever set himself to collect and investigate afresh the materials for the early history of Islam, but either abstracted them from al-Tabari (sometimes supplemented by al-Baladhuri), or else began where al-Tabari left off. At the same time, the poverty of the latter part of al-Tabari's work gave warning that the purely traditionist approach to history was no longer sufficient. The bureaucratic organization of government brought the class of officials and courtiers to the fore as authorities for political history and relegated the men of religion to the second place. For this reason also, the third century marks the end of a stage in Arabic historiography. But Prof. Gibb draws our attention to the fact that Tabari described the conquest of Spain by the Muslims, such an important affair, within six lines only. this betrays his want of sense of proportion.

The cause of Tabari's weakness as pointed out by Gibb :

the weakness or insufficiency in Tabari's traditionist approach to history hinted above may be explained by the fact that Tabari relied on the reports of Saif b, Umar, an Akhabari, at best a pseudo-historian more than the reports of al-Waqidi, a reputed historian, simply because the latter sometimes took reports from Jewish sources.

But his merits as a historian are considerable. Besides his authority and comprehensiveness Tabari possessed like other great Muslim historians the sense of time and accuracy in dating the events which became the hall mark of Muslim historiography. Tabari has arranged all the events according to the year of happening and has collected as many versions of an event as he was able to find out. Tabari was a true historian in the sense that he wrote history without any

motives and did not try to shape it according to particular interests and objects. According to Encyclopedia of Islam, he refused so many official positions and devoted whole heartedly and independently to history reading and writing. A life sketch of Tabari may not be without interest.

Tabari was born at Anmul in Tabaristan from where he proceeded to Rayy. Here one of his teachers Muhammad bin Humaid Razi, communicated to him more than one lakh traditions. From Rayy Tabari went to Baghdad to attend the lectures of the learned for some time and then left for Basra, having stopped for a time at wasit. From Basra he went to Kufa, where he learnt another one lakh traditions from one sheikh Abbu Kuraib. From Kufa he came back to Baghdad where he took to the studies of law and the Holy Quran. Thence he traveled westward and having halted at some Syrian cities he proceeded to Fustat (253 A.H.) In Fustat the most hospitable Savant was Ali bin Sarraj who admired Tabari's knowledge in the religious sciences as well as in poetry. From Fustat he returned to Baghdad and from there to Tabaristan which he visited again 290 A.H. On his return to Baghdad he incurred the displeasure of the Hambalities owing to a remark of his about their founder which was regarded as objectionable. Tabari had also to quit Tabaristan after his last visit. because he did not support the cursing of the three caliphs from the pulpit of the mosque, a practice then rife in that province even though he had Shiite proclivities. So, he was broad-minded and tolerant in his vies, a great quality for a historian. Tabari had learnt the Quran by heart at the age of seven and had led the prayer at the age of eight and had taken down tradition at the age of nine. He breathed his last in **310 A.H.** 923 A.D.

Masudi

After Tabari the most important figure in historiography is Masudi a renowned historian, geographer and philosopher, who was born in Baghdad. He traveled in Spain, Russia, China, India, Syria and Egypt. Thus he undertook extensive tours to gather first hand information for his works on history and geography. His history, a most extensive work **Kitab Akhbar-uz-Zaman**, written in 30 volumes with a supplement of **Kitab-al-Awsat**, a chronological sketch of general history.

The substance of the two parts was gathered by him in **Muruj-us-Dhahabwa Maadin-al-Jawahir** (Meadows of gold and Mines of Precious stones) which is a history of the universe from creation to 947 A.D. It embraces social and literary history and discussions as well as geographic descriptions Unlike Tabari's history. Masudi has arranged events around dynasties and empires. He did not follow the path of Tabari but created his own style of history writing. His encyclopedic and historio geographical work includes his researches on Indo-Persian Roman and Jewish history and religion as also history of Islam. Muslim historiography was fully developed at the hands of Tabari and Masudi. They were followed by a band of historians like Miskawih, Ibn Khallikan, Abul Fida and Ibn Khaldun. His famous works are **Muruj-uz-Zahab**, **Kitabul Tanbih** and **Risalat-zaman**. Throughout Masudi shows the very same lively interest in non Muslims as in muslim peoples. He has been called muslim Herodotus for his wide interest and humanistic attitude. "Certainly his book" says Khuda Baksh, stands unrivalled in its combination of instruction and amusement." H.E. Barnes says that Masudi possessed the same avid curiosity and zeal for information as did the father of history.

Ibn Khaldun as Historian :

Ibn Khaldun, De Boer observes. "comes forward with a claim to establish new philosophical discipline, of which Aristotle had no conception". The historical works of his forerunners, particularly of Tabari and Masudi, have had most influence on the development of his thoughts.

According to Walter J. Fischel the historian Tabari is regarded by Ibn Khaldun as one of the few good historians, and counted among those historians of whom there are "not more than the fingers on one hand". Ibn Khaldun leans heavily on Tabari's historical works and draws material from him for his history of the non Arabic peoples and for the illustration of his own socio-philosophical views.

Masudi discarded the old school of historiography which followed closely on the traditionist method and conceived of a new style and technique of history writing which took cognizance of society and social aspects of human life. This particular standpoint was fully developed by Ibn Khaldun and he made a scientific and analytic study of history, which established history as a science a subject which teaches us that it is not a mere catalogue of facts, nor a mere narrative of past happenings, but a science to be studied for understanding the causes of the rise and fall of States and nations. It is Ibn Khaldun's Muqaddima (prolegomena) which forms his social and political philosophy.

Kitab al-Ibar & Muqaddima :

In the context of the above finding and views let us now discuss Ibn Khaldun's philosophy of history as it has been presented in his Muqaddima. The Muqaddima (Prolegomena) is the long preface or introduction to a larger book Kitab-al Ibar of which it constitutes the first volume. In this volume, viz., the Muqaddima the phenomena of society and State are discussed at length, and in which the author expounds his sociological and philosophical views. The second book of four volumes begins with an account of the history of ancient nations such as those of the pre Islamic Arabs. Babylonians and Nabateans, Copts, Israelites and Jews, early Christians, Persians, Greeks, Romans, Goths, Turks & Franks upto 8th/14th century and then deals with the history of Islam, the Umayyads, the Abbasides and other dynasties until the author's time. The third book dealing with the history of the Berbers up to the days of the author, fills the sixth and the seventh volumes. Ibn Khaldun concluded his Kitab al-Ibar with some chapters about his life and activities. This part, usually called Autobiography, consists of several long chapters in which he describes his origin and genealogy, his early education, his teachers and the books he read, his activities in the political sphere of North Africa and Spain, the various posts and positions he held under almost all the leading rulers and dynasties of the Maghrib of his time, his visit to Granada, his mission to the Christian King Pedro the Cruel and then his retirement into the fortress of Qatat Ibn Salama in order to write his History, his return to Tunis, and his subsequent departure from Tunis to Egypt in the year 784 A.H./1382 A.D. In writing about his life in Egypt Ibn Khaldun dwelt at great length on his relations with the Mamluk Sultan Barquq, his various academic appointments to the al-Ashar, his appointment as Malekite chief judge, the intrigues against him, his resignation from the post of Qazi, his pilgrimage to Mecca, and his return there from Egypt.

Ibn Khaldun, in his Ibar, Volume V, has given an account of the Tartars, of Chengiz Khan and his sons, and of the early campaigns and expeditions of Timur upto the year 1395 A.D. In these last chapters on his Autobiography he continues Timur's biography and activities upto the year 1401 A.D. an account of which is so valuable for being based on a direct contact with the conqueror and on intimate knowledge of his personality.

As regards the Muqaddima in which Ibn Khaldun's some remarkable historical philosophy has been expounded comments of the world famous historians have held high opinion. Some observations of those the Muqaddima. scholars will be of great interest and will serve the purpose of giving us a clear idea of the genius of Ibn Khaldun. Ibn Khaldun's fame as one of the greatest historians of Islam, as the forerunner of modern sociology, has been acknowledged by modern scholars in glowing terms. A. J. Toynbee declared it to be 'the greatest work of its kind that has been created by any mind in any time or place. G. Sarton regards it as "one of the noblest and most impressive monuments of medieval thought". Nicholson thus evaluates the Muqaddima: "No Muslim had attempted to trace the deeply hidden forces of events, to expose the moral and physical forces at work beneath the surface or to divide the immutable laws of national progress and decay. He stood far above his age, and his own countrymen had admired rather than followed him. His intellectual descendants are the great medieval and modern historians of Europe Machiavelli and Vico and Gibbon. He (Ibn Khaldun), M.A. Enan says, is distinguished from his predecessors for excellent arrangement and presentation, as well as for clearness, precision in the division of subjects and in making tables of contents of one fundamental and sound insight, namely, by considering every thing as a function of man and human social organization.

Ibn Khaldun's Philosophy of History

History, as conceived by Ibn Khaldun, is the record of human society, of world civilization, of the changes that take place in the nature of that society, such as savagery, sociability, and group solidarity, of revolutions and uprisings by one set of people against another with the resulting kingdoms and States with their various ranks of the different activities and occupations of men, whether for gaining their livelihood or in the various sciences and crafts, in general of all the transformations that society undergoes in its very nature (Muqaddima, Vol. 1, P. 56) As a Philosopher of history Ibn Khaldun in his Muqaddima "prescribed for the first time a theory of historical development which takes due cognizance of the Physical facts of climate and geography as well as the moral and spiritual forces at work. As one who endeavors to find and formulate laws of natural progress and decay Ibn Khaldun may be considered the discoverer of the true scope and nature of history. History was so long mere record of events and chronicle of Kings and dynasties, but Ibn Khaldun for the first time saw through these phenomena the stages of the growth of the social and political lives of nations. He studies the effects of geographical features, climate, air, food etc. upon the growth and evolution of civilization and culture: in other words, the above things influence and determine the nature and pattern of human character and civilization, thought and culture, society and state. Dr. Inayatullah says that Ibn Khaldun dealt with the subject of geographical influence more fully, and based his survey of human civilization on a careful geographical analysis.

Influence of climate

Ibn Khaldun, has clearly examined the influence of climate upon the character temperament taste and culture of individuals and nation. He has expounded his theory by citing examples from history. He has illustrated his theory that people living in very cold climatic regions such as Siberia or Lapland or people near the Equator, exposed to excessive heat, cannot make much progress and contribute to human thought. According to him. Nations living in temperate zones such as Romans, Greeks, Persians and Arabs, more than any other nation, have contributed to civilization. In our days we find that Englishman and French and such other nations living in not very cold climatic regions made progress in subsequent times. This example has only confirmed the theory of Ibn Khaldun. On the contrary, he says that countries with extreme climates are much inferior in civilization and culture. Even, he says man's common sense and wisdom, habits and wisdom are also affected by longitude and latitude.

Group Mind and Other Factors in the Formation of State.

In the formation of State, Ibn Khaldun says, one of the factors is the sense of oneness or group mind, which he termed as 'Asabiyah'. This group mind and religion are two of the most important factors at the root of the evolution of states. At the same time he does not assign to religion, according to Khuda Bakhsh, a place of importance as a formative element in civilization. In this respect, the historian observes, Ibn Khaldun is the first representative of an intellectual tendency which manifested itself in the West only five hundred years later. In the words of Franz Rosenthal: "Religious fervor and the appearance of Prophets, who incidentally cannot succeed in this world without concrete political support, can intensify and accelerate political movements. History offers instances, of these the most prominent one being the phenomenal, superhuman success of Islam.

In Modern Times

But in modern times Group Mind or Unity of purpose has played more than religion or any other factor in the formation of such heterogeneous states as Switzerland Belgium, Canada and the United States of America.

Different Stages of Civilization

further Ibn Khaldun has maintained human civilization advances from pastoral and nomadic to urban and city life and ultimately to vast imperial dominion. The nomadic simple rude and natural life is replaced by a life of opulence and luxury which leads to indolence in place of previous activity which again produces effeminate nature in men, rendering them unfit for protection from foreign aggression. In that stage the ruler is obliged to appoint mercenaries in order to save the state. In this stage the state does not last long and ceases to exist and dies a natural death. The other process may also begin to work when the autocracy or absolutism of the ruler, because of people's inertia or indolence, may be ultimately challenged by popular movement and the state in that case may grow strong and virile and the cycle begins to work again.

Further more, Ibn Khaldun says that the state has an organic growth. Like a human being it has its birth, youth, old age decay and death. This organic conception of society and biological interpretation of history places Ibn Khaldun in the category of modern exponents of this important school of sociological thought. We feel as if Oswald Spengler was merely re-capitulating the theories and concepts of Ibn Khaldun.

Ibn Khaldun's Criticism of other historians:

Before finally closing the evaluation of Ibn Khaldun's genius and his many sided talents it will not be out of place to mention the points of criticism leveled by the great historian against some general errors committed by some historians.

Writing of history requires numerous sources of information and varied knowledge. The historian, Ibn Khaldun says, should try to grasp the truth and be careful of slips and errors. If he trusts his information or data and does not try to ascertain the truth or authenticity thereof by means of laws governing historical development and by comparing with nearer and contemporary events, he is often liable to deviate from the truth.

Historians should never be credulous and should not accept what is transmitted to them without re-evaluating them. For instance, Masudi and other historians (obviously quoting from Jewish source) wrote that Bani Israil (Israelites) numbered 600,000 after their flight from Egypt. Now Moses was the son of Imran, Who was the son of Kohath, who was the son of Levi, who was the son of Yaqub called Israel. And when Yaqub, his children and their children entered Egypt their number was only 50. How could the descendants of Israel multiply into 600,000 in three generation. It is obviously a physical impossibility: and so the figure is not a historical fact but the result of fancy and imagination.